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If You Heard What I Heard 'Night of Resilience' Gala, Idan Raichel Performs at VBS

November 14, 2025 | Jewish Journal of Greater Los Angeles, The (CA)
Author: Jewish Journal Staff | Section: Movers & Shakers | 509 Words
OpenURL Link

The If You Heard What I Heard (IYH) "Night of Resilience" gala, a glitzy affair drawing adults of all ages committed to the work of remembrance, was held Nov. 2 at Peterson Automotive Museum.

The evening honored IYH Board Member Aaron Aftergood for his leadership and commitment to the organization's mission while recognizing Holocaust survivor Andrew Stern—"whose courage reminds us why our work matters so profoundly," the group's founder and executive director, Carolyn Siegel, said.

Temple Beth Am Senior Rabbi Adam Kligfeld presented the award to Aftergood.

Actor Mark Feuerstein ("Guns and Moses") emceed the event, billed as a night of comedy, live music and unity that featured comedians Dan Levy and Moshe Kasher, magician Justin Willman and Jewish folk-pop band Distant Cousins, which filled the room with Jewish joy through their music. Levy had the audience in stitches as he riffed on his overbearing Jewish mother, and Willman wowed the crowd with mentalist-like shtick that left everyone scratching their heads and pondering just how he did it.

The event kicked off with attendees gathering in the museum for appetizers and cocktails, including grilled cheese sandwiches prepared by chef Eric Greenspan. Also preparing food for the evening was Chef Yoav Schverd. Then, everyone found their seats for the evening's main program, which highlighted the important work IYH has been doing. Stern, who was born in a basement in a Jewish ghetto in Budapest in 1944, appeared onstage with his granddaughter. He was presented with a certificate that had been signed by State Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel.

Founded by Siegel in April 2021 in response to an antisemitic incident targeting a Los Angeles synagogue, IYH gathers recorded testimonies from grandchildren of Holocaust survivors—the last generation to hear survivors' histories firsthand. To date, the organization has recorded nearly 70 interviews, which are available on the group's website.

IYH also offers a summer education series, which brings its interviewees—grandchildren of survivors—to summer camps throughout California to share their stories. Additionally, the organization brings young adults together for events intended to foster community, including a recent havdalah in West Hollywood that featured schmoozing, cocktails and a plated dinner.

At a time when studies show knowledge gaps about the Shoah, the organization is having a lasting impact on Holocaust education.

On Nov. 5, Encino-based Valley Beth Shalom (VBS) hosted renowned Israeli singer Idan Raichel as part of its concert series, produced by VBS Cantor Jacqueline Rafii.

Raichel performed many of his well-known songs, accompanying himself on piano and guitar. The VBS Youth Choir joined him for a moving rendition of "Bo'i" ("Come with Me") and Cantor Rafii shared the stage with him for the heartfelt "Im Telech" (If You Go").

The concert series has proven to be a great success, drawing not only VBS members but also music lovers from across the community. The synagogue's next concert, "Africa to Israel: Our Bridge to Zion," takes place on Feb. 1, at 7 p.m., featuring artist JoDavi and Pastor Dumisani Washington, founder of the Institute for Black Solidarity with

Israel, appearing alongside VBS Senior Rabbi Nolan Lebovitz, Cantor Rafii, and guest musicians.

By Ayala Or-El, Contributing Writer

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Journal Staff, J. (2025, November 14). If You Heard What I Heard 'Night of Resilience' Gala, Idan Raichel Performs at VBS. *Jewish Journal of Greater Los Angeles, The (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A45BA72A700ECA0.